

CHAPTER 13

Garage or Basement - The Final Frontier



Time Budget: 12–20 hours (largest single project)

Impact: Capstone achievement, major storage functionality — see Appendix for your room-by-room checklists.

This final frontier of home organization is a unique project in this book. These spaces may represent years or decades of items, projects, and things you abandoned. Decluttering the basement or the garage will represent a capstone effort. For some, it could take a whole day or twenty-four hours spread over several sessions.

The basement or garage can be an overwhelming space. You must draw on your decluttering knowledge from the other parts of the home. Given that you’ve had success getting to this point and have developed skills, this space, although nebulous, can be conquered.

Why This Comes Last

This space is last because it represents the items that were set aside to be dealt with later. During the decluttering efforts in the prior rooms, you probably encountered items and punted on making a

decision about them. Those items were too important to directly discard at that point, so you sent them to the garage or the basement to be dealt with later. This space can be thought of as a museum of your prior chapters of life, hobbies, abandoned projects, inherited items, and the list goes on. This is okay.

It's fair to say you needed to address the rest of the house first. You need to have worked on smaller problems, built your decision-making capacity, and learned to let go of items that are no longer relevant to the current chapter of your life. You learned how to release the stuff but not the memories with techniques like digitizing. At this point, you've begun to see the value of space and peace, and this has prepared you for the basement and garage.

The Garage and Basement Reality

Let's conduct a short experiment. Stand in the basement or garage and have a look around. How many items have you not opened in the last year, two years, five years? This is a rhetorical question, but you know these items are occupying valuable real estate in your home.

Many people don't park a car in the garage simply because the car cannot fit due to clutter. The garage is designed to protect cars from the elements and from potential theft or vandalism. When you can't park your car in the garage due to clutter, those items cost you functional space. Similarly, for your basement, if it's full of storage boxes, you never get to access or enjoy using the basement. The finished square footage is wasted.

There's a cost to storing items. Obviously, there is the space it occupies, but there's also a mental weight knowing that you have the stuff but don't use it. And, as we've mentioned, there's a missed opportunity to use the functional space. Over time, these costs accumulate unconsciously in your mind.

Step 1: Mental Preparation

For most, this space will require a major decluttering effort, so prepare yourself mentally and give yourself the best chance to succeed. You'll need to set some realistic expectations. This space will likely take five sessions of maybe four hours each. If you anchor to this view, it will prevent frustration that might cause you to stall—or worse, not finish the effort.

During the process, like other parts of the decluttering effort, you'll be confronted with items that were purchased but never used and the sick feeling of wasted money. You must accept that the money is already gone. Keeping the unused items doesn't recover that expense. Let go of the guilt and focus on creating a functional space.

It's likely that you will get dirtier in this process than other rooms, as both the garage and basement accumulate dust and grime. You'll encounter items that you haven't moved or touched in years and items covered in cobwebs (and other unpleasant things). Wearing gloves is useful, as it gives you more initiative to dig in and work through the dirty items.

This project should be scheduled strategically when the weather is predicted to be moderate. You don't want to attack the garage during the summer heat or the freezing cold of winter. If you live somewhere where the temperatures are generally more extreme, then plan to have shorter sessions over a longer period or take more breaks.

For the donations, try to plan out the donation pickup schedule as you get into the project. This promotes accountability and prevents donation items from sitting in the garage for prolonged periods. Depending on your location, some charities will pick up large items for free. Some declutterers might need to rent a dumpster to remove broken appliances, furniture, or just significant amounts of trash.

If this is the case, decide beforehand and arrange your sessions to coincide with its arrival.

Sometimes you might need muscle to help you move items physically through the process. Arrange this beforehand so it doesn't become an obstacle or deter you from the process.

Step 2: Zone-by-Zone Decluttering

You don't want to declutter the garage or basement all at once. This will tend to overwhelm you and likely cause you to stall. The best approach is to work through this space by creating zones and working through them. (This technique was introduced earlier in the book.) Look at the garage or basement space and determine the potential categories, such as sports equipment, lawn and garden, automotive supplies, and miscellaneous. The miscellaneous category will be the worst because it's a catchall of items that don't fit elsewhere.

Strategically, you want to go for a quick win and start with a category you know you can make decisions about easily. For example, if you actively use sports equipment, then that might be a place to start. Seasonal decorations might be another quick decision category, as you might be familiar with what has been in use versus what wasn't used during the latest season. Don't attack more than one zone or category at once; pick a category and finish it. You want to complete a zone to build momentum and give you confidence. During the process, you want to be able to look up and see the zones stack up one by one as they're completed.

For each selected zone, pull everything into a central area and go through the usual process. Sort it, make decisions, and organize what you're keeping. Clean the area where those items were stored. Once the zone is done, rinse and repeat the process by moving on to the next zone.

This structure and process create visible progress. If you pull everything into the central area and begin the sorting process, it would be too overwhelming. Moving through the items by zone allows you to stop at the end of a session without having a totally dysfunctional space.

Step 3: The Moving Question

As you sort through the items in your garage or basement, pretend that you're moving to a new house. Specifically, ask yourself if you were moving to a new house, would this be moved also? If the answer is no, there is no reason to store the item any longer. This question cuts to the heart of whether the item is worth taking up valuable real estate.

Utilizing the moving house process to think through useful items is a valuable lens through which to evaluate the clutter. Moving is both expensive and exhausting if it involves hiring movers and packing your belongings. If you don't intend to use the item, there's no sense in packing or paying for the moving expense. You'll find that many items will fail this test and should be donated or discarded.

Step 4: Open Every Unknown Box

Most of you will have boxes with mystery contents. You need to open the boxes now and make decisions on the key items. These boxes often contain items you forgot about and then subsequently bought replacements for, things that should be trashed and some that are worth keeping.

A useful technique is to use the **six-month rule**. Simply put, if you haven't opened or thought of the box in the last six months, you don't need the contents in your current life. Some of these boxes you have might not have been thought of or opened in several years.

As you go through the process of opening boxes, make sure you sort that box. Don't repack the boxes to deal with later. Trash, donate, relocate, or keep each item. Often, there are some sentimental items that require deeper or more emotional decision-making. As illustrated in Chapter 10, a useful technique is to limit sentimental items to the size of a large bin. Items that have less sentimental value can be digitized so that the photos can be reflected on in the future.

Step 5: Category-Specific Guidance

When evaluating categories of items in the garage or basement, here are some useful guidelines as you work through the zones.

Tools tend to accumulate because they appear to be permanently useful. However, there can be some improvements. If there are duplicate tools, keep the best one; you don't need four of the same item. If there are broken tools, discard them. Generally, if they haven't been repaired, they will never be repaired. If there are tools you accumulated for a hobby that has since been abandoned, these items take up space and should be donated.

The tools should be held in a toolbox or on a pegboard for visibility. The pegboard can have outlines of the tools or labels so the home for each tool is visible, with the goal of maintaining some type of order.

Sporting goods will tend to represent either your past activities or ambitious future aspirations. Try to keep the equipment for the sports you currently play and those you've made concrete plans to take up. A good rule of thumb is that if you or a family member hasn't used the equipment in the year, it will never be used. If there are younger children who might grow into the equipment, then that's a valid reason to keep it.

Holiday decorations should be limited based on what was displayed in recent years. Assign a designated large bin for each

holiday, and if there are more decorations than fit in the bin, then there are too many. Most holidays should have one bin whereas Christmas decorations tend to need more— maybe two to three bins. Some common culprits to be discarded or donated are items that were inherited or gifted to you but that you never use. Also, there may be a variety of decorations that have malfunctioned yet continue to be stored.

Lawn and garden supplies should align to your current lawn and garden maintenance needs. Often, there are items representing hobbies we wanted to take up, like pots purchased with the hope of growing flowers, but this was never achieved. Other times, people have downgraded to a smaller home and transported the lawn supplies without assessing their usefulness. For example, you might not need that riding mower anymore. If there are multiple bags of similar products like fertilizer, consolidate them. Generally, keep supplies that you use easily accessible while disposing of the rest.

Automotive items tend to accumulate beyond what most people commonly use. Today, many people don't perform car maintenance themselves for a variety of reasons. Some people wash their cars, while others prefer to take them to the car wash. Some change their own oil, while others take it to the shop. Any items that aren't used should be discarded: old car parts, excess motor oil, or even car washing supplies. There are some die-hard car enthusiasts who could benefit from your extra supplies.

Paint is one of the most common garage or basement clutter items. After your major painting project is complete, there's likely a partial can of paint remaining for each color. If you want to keep these cans for touchups, make sure they're labeled by room. These old paint cans may sit for years until the next painting project, at which time you will likely go to the store and pick new paint. If there are empty, dried out, or partial paint cans, dispose of them

per your local guidelines, which might include drop-off locations to assist in disposal. Paint should not be thrown in the trash.

Furniture waiting in the garage tends to stay there indefinitely. If there's garage furniture that hasn't found a permanent location in the last year, arrange for it to be donated unless there's a concrete plan for the furniture. If you have furniture in the garage, your car might not fit in the garage. You should reclaim the garage for some functional use.

Sentimental items are items most have tended to avoid, simply carrying the existing boxes forward and never venturing to look through the contents. These could be boxes from parents' homes, old school papers, and memorabilia—often decades of stuff that leads to full sessions of emotional decision-making. Apply the principles from Chapter 10, utilizing the one large bin maximum. One useful technique mentioned earlier was to digitize items you find somewhat precious. Only keep the things that bring you joy so that you aren't holding onto things out of obligation.

Step 6: The Donation and Disposal Process

As we mentioned earlier, before jumping into the basement or garage and starting your decluttering effort, you need to arrange where the unwanted items will go to. If not, this will kill the momentum of your decluttering effort as bags slated for donations stack up. If you expect to have large, bulky items to be donated, research donation pickup services. Similarly, if you expect to have heavy trash-related items, arrange those removal services. If there's hazardous waste items such as paint, plan for their safe removal to protect the environment and be compliant with regulations.

Some items can be removed by yourself via your car, while other items should be scheduled for pickup. All these methods allow you to plan for the orderly removal of the clutter in batches. These steps

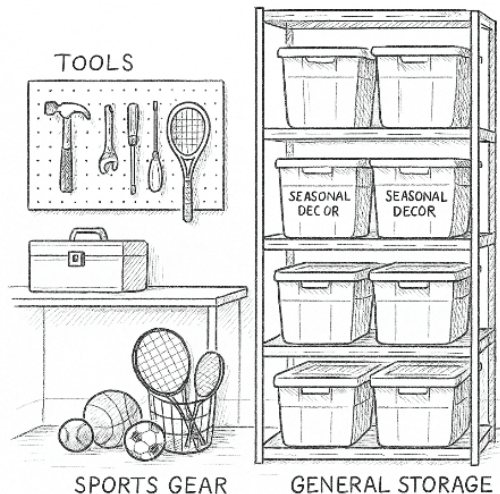
serve as small psychological wins as you see the space open and free up, allowing you to build motivation and tackle more zones.

Step 7: Organization Systems for What Remains

After decluttering a specified zone, organize the remaining items you're keeping into proper systems that maintain order and prevent reaccumulation.

It's best to use heavy duty shelving built from metal that can bear significant weight and will survive literally for a lifetime. Try to maximize both the vertical and the horizontal space. Once the shelving is in place, the space above the shelves can't be used, so build shelves to the ceiling if possible. Similarly, depending on the wall space, try to extend the shelving to the edge of the wall to prevent having a useless few feet of space between the shelving and the adjacent wall.

The containers should be clear bins with labels for the items stored within. If possible, label your bins on all six sides; this gives visibility from all angles depending on your vantage point. You don't want opaque mystery boxes.



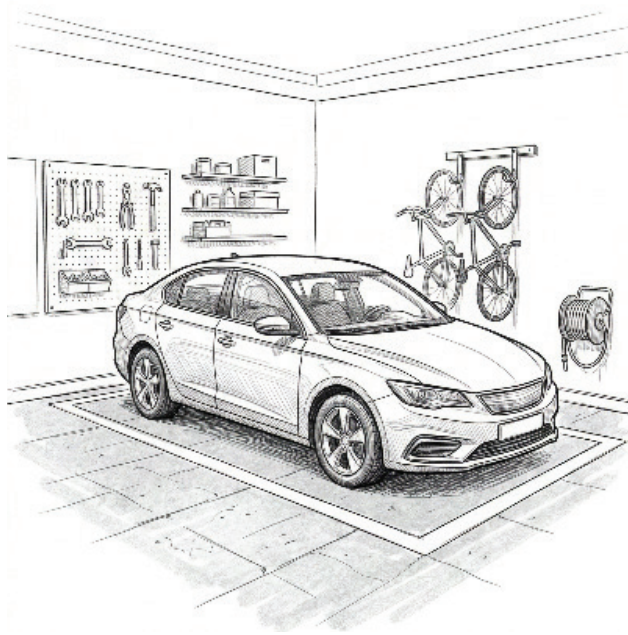
Look towards the floor and implement the **off-the-floor rule**, which basically says nothing should live on the floor except vehicles and large equipment. Usually, if there's water damage or flooding, it happens at the floor level. The shelving elevates everything from potential damage and provides a clean and more functional space.

Once you create your zones, assign categories for your zones. For example, you might have a corner zone where you store seasonal decorations, and within that you might store your Halloween, Easter, and Christmas bins. This creates functional departments for your storage space, which allows you to find and return items efficiently.

When storing items, you should consider their durability related to temperature or moisture. Items sensitive to temperature and humidity, like photos and documents, shouldn't be stored in the non-air-conditioned garage. If you went through the effort of sorting and preserving these items, you don't want them to be damaged due to an act of God.

Step 8: The Parking Test

If you have a garage, a simple test is to ask yourself if you can park your car inside it. If not, then the problem is typically too much clutter or the need for more robust storage solutions. The primary purpose of the garage is to house and protect your vehicle. If it can't do that, then it's not functional.



When the initially decluttered garage still can't fit the car, examine your storage solutions more critically. Potentially, you can use shelving mounted above the height of the car or ceiling-mounted storage racks. Both allow you to have freedom of movement around your vehicle. Obviously, you can remove or relocate items to achieve the functionality of a garage.

Step 9: Final Assessment and Maintenance

When you think the decluttering effort in the garage or basement is complete, perform the final assessment. Walk around the space and determine if you can find what you need within a few minutes. Assess if there's good visibility and accessibility. Most importantly, the items that you see should serve your current life rather than being remnants of past chapters of your life.

As a part of your maintenance protocols to prevent the reaccumulation of clutter, use the one-in, one-out rule. For each item entering the basement or garage, one must leave to avoid accumulating clutter. In addition, every three months, take a walk through for items that might have migrated here but weren't addressed. Act to either discard, relocate, or donate the items. On a seasonal basis, make a concerted effort to swap out items, perform a mini-audit, and remove any items that you didn't use last season.

The Achievement

When both the garage and the basement are complete, it represents the final frontier of the decluttering journey. These were the spaces that you likely resisted decluttering, had history with, and were most emotional about. Finishing the effort indicates that you've built up the mindset to have a clutter-free life and the skills to do it.

Throughout this process, you made hard decisions and learned to value space and peace more than keeping a lot of stuff. You learned to focus on the current chapter of your life rather than the past or potential future outcomes.

Enjoy and savor the moment as all the rooms in your home are organized. You transformed your home from one of chaos to a functional space, creating workable systems along the way. The maintenance will require minimal daily effort, which allows you to live rather than manage clutter.

The garage and basement are the end of your initial organizing journey. Now it's about entering the maintenance phase. You can evaluate items before entering the home, release items that aren't serving you, and maintain organized systems throughout the home.

Again, think of your life as a book, and you are moving through the chapters. You've closed the chapter on clutter and started a new chapter on functionality and peace. Now it's time to enjoy your home!

PHASE IV

SUSTAINABLE LIVING
AND MINDFUL
EXPANSION

CHAPTER 14

Maintenance Routines - Keeping the Calm Alive



The organization of your home and each room involved thousands of decisions as you examined and assessed various items. You released items through donations or discarding that were no longer important to you and created systems that support your current life. The decluttering work was no doubt considerable, but there's still more. Maintenance systems are required; otherwise, clutter will begin to creep back in. Here, we reinforce how to maintain the calm that was created through your efforts.

The Maintenance Mindset

A useful analogy is to think of decluttering as working out and maintenance as the fitness routine. In other words, decluttering puts your home into shape, while maintenance keeps it that way. Decluttering is time-consuming, while maintenance should be much faster, measured in minutes rather than hours.

We need to maintain our home because life just happens. You'll receive new mail, buy things, and receive gifts. The kids will bring home papers and artwork, and people will make messes. It's unstoppable but normal. Unlike before your decluttering efforts, you now have systems to process rather than allow for haphazard accumulation.

In science, there's the concept of entropy, and this speaks to the measure of natural disorder and energy spreading over time. In other words, your home naturally moves toward disorder unless energy is applied to maintain order. Your home requires maintenance; otherwise, the organized closet will become disorganized over time. Fighting entropy requires small and consistent efforts that stop clutter from overwhelming you and becoming major projects.

These small efforts aren't about scheduling reorganizations of your home. They are all maintenance items that safeguard the time and energy you invested in decluttering efforts, whether daily routines, weekly check-ins, or monthly resets.

Daily Maintenance: The Nightly Reset

Nightly resets are an anchor to your daily maintenance by stopping clutter before it has a chance to take hold. Executing the nightly reset will make your home feel organized and manageable. If you complete this fifteen-minute nightly routine consistently, in the morning, you'll wake up to a relative level of calmness. The Nightly Resets were described in Phase III in their respective chapters.

The Morning Quick-Check

The morning check builds on the evening reset, preserving the momentum. It should be quick and not a major undertaking. The

relevant Morning Quick-Checks were described in Phase III in their respective chapters.

Weekly Maintenance: Spot-Checks and Deep Cleaning

We need the weekly maintenance because some areas will just collect clutter despite your best efforts and the daily resets. This will prevent these areas from getting out of control. For many people, there will be four to five areas where items appear to accumulate quickly. The typical hot spots are flat surfaces that invite items, such as the entry tables, counters, or dining table. Generally, your specific hotspots will depend upon your family habits and traffic flow.

Attack these hot spots using targeted approaches of perhaps ten minutes for each spot. Simply remove any items at the hotspot and return them to their proper location, designate them for donation, or put them in the trash. This will prevent accumulation and allow the area to look and feel uncluttered.

The relevant Weekly Maintenance routines were described in Phase III in their respective chapters.

Monthly Maintenance: Rotating Deep Dives

Monthly maintenance focuses on areas not covered in the daily or weekly care that need specific periodic attention. Typically, it will take two to three hours for each of these rotating deep dives. Here, we lay out common deep dives distributed throughout the year.

Month one focuses on cleaning the refrigerator and freezer. It's like the initial decluttering effort but somewhat easier. The initial effort will have sorted out most of the clutter, and now it's more about maintenance. Start by removing the contents of the refrigerator, for example, and sorting through the items. Look for

expired items and send them to the trash. If there are duplicate items, consolidate. Give the refrigerator shelves and drawers a good wipe or cleaning.

Month two moves to the pantry and food storage. Again, this is like the initial decluttering effort specified in Chapter 5. Reorganize the pantry so that similar items live together if they've inadvertently shifted around. Consolidate duplicate packages. Wipe down the shelves to remove crumbs and spills.

Month three moves from the kitchen to the bathroom. Check for expiration dates on products in the medicine cabinet, cosmetics, and skincare. Refine the organization of the drawers and cabinets as needed. Some areas will require some deep cleaning, such as behind the toilets and inside the cabinets. Wash or clean items that haven't been frequently cleaned, like the shower curtain or the bathmat. In general, you're addressing items that haven't been touched in the daily or weekly maintenance routines.

Month four allows you to visit your closets. If you implemented the backward hanger technique to identify unworn clothes, you might be at the point of determining which clothes are candidates for donation. The clothes suitable for donation can be removed. Over the past year, you might have discovered that your shelf organization wasn't working optimally, so this is the chance to tweak and refine as necessary. Clear the closet floor to prevent it from becoming overstuffed again.

Month five focuses on the kids' rooms. This could involve removing clothes that no longer fit, rotating in age-appropriate toys, and donating younger toys. Examine areas that tend to collect items, like under the bed or between the furniture. Monthly maintenance keeps the kids and you from becoming overwhelmed.

Month six is for paperwork and files. Often you won't have enough time to address all the paper or digital items daily or weekly, so it's necessary to set aside time monthly. If there are current papers,

make sure they're filed appropriately. For medical records, make sure the list of emergency contacts is up to date. This saves time when schools request the information. This general maintenance helps promote a proper paper management system.

Month seven is for spot-checking the garage or basement. Take a visual walk through and identify items that may have been inadvertently set there. Feel free to reorganize items that are commonly used to a more accessible row in storage. Check for moisture or pest issues that may need attention. This monthly check maintains the progress made in the major organization effort of Chapter 13.

Month eight directs focus to the linen closets, and this should be a relatively easy lift. It might involve reorganizing some shelves that are a bit jumbled or replacing some sheets that are worn. If there are medical supplies in the linen closet, then a quick check for expired medical supplies is in order. This helps to preserve the decluttered linen closet that was introduced in Chapter 10.

Month nine addresses the entryway closet as a separate category than other closets. Here, the focus is on seasonal swapping and purging unnecessary items. The entryway should be cleaned vigorously with a vacuum, mop, and a wipe-down of the surfaces. This maintenance keeps the entryway functional and clutter-free-looking.

Month ten tackles digital decluttering. This section focuses more on managing, organizing, and deleting the duplicates of all things digital. Have you noticed that you seem to have an increasing number of useless emails? Rather than scrolling by unwanted emails, take some time to unsubscribe. Clear out any unused apps on your phone, tablet, and computer. For a deeper dive on digital items, see Chapter 15.

Month eleven focuses on deep cleaning kitchen tools and appliances. This applies to the oven, dishwasher, and microwave. If

the drawers are messy, reorganize them. Determine if there are items that can be donated. These steps target key areas of the kitchen beyond what's covered in the weekly surface cleaning.

Month twelve is preparation for the holidays. Examine the holiday decorations before putting them up. This allows you to isolate the unused items for donation rather than just carrying them forward into storage for another year. Organize the gift-wrapping supplies and plan for any gifts by making space. This proactive approach will reduce typical holiday stress.

These monthly tasks are distributed over the year and touch on key areas of your home so that each area receives deeper focus once a year. Based upon your current circumstances, feel free to adjust the monthly activities to align with your schedule. For example, backward hangers might need a bit more time to gather data after the initial decluttering efforts. If so, closets might be moved to later than month four in your schedule. This prevents any space from deteriorating significantly between maintenance sessions.

Seasonal Maintenance: Transitions and Deep Cleaning

When the seasons change, it's a natural time to conduct seasonal maintenance and deep cleaning. During this time, equipment and clothing should be rotated, and a session of deeper cleaning is in order. These are usually spread across the weekend and will include clothing swaps, changing outdoor equipment, and aligning your items with the weather.

Spring cleaning or spring maintenance involves changing winter clothes for summer wardrobes. If there are winter items that were not worn, send them to the donation bin before they accumulate in storage the next year. There might be a need to prepare outdoor items like garden hoses or sprinklers for use and store the snow shovels and

snow blowers. In general, these activities align with saying goodbye to the cold weather and welcoming the warmer temperatures.

Summer maintenance focuses the review on outdoor toys and equipment. Inspect outdoor items such as pool supplies, camping gear, or beachwear to make sure they're in working order. This will help maintain your outdoor spaces and ensure the equipment is ready when the time comes.

Fall maintenance signifies a change from summer clothes to fall and winter clothes. It's also the time school begins, so be sure to organize the backpacks and related back-to-school items. Entertainment and play activities tend to retreat indoors, so adjust your storage and organization for this. Generally, look at items that focus on transitioning from warmer to colder weather.

Winter is the jolly season, so prepare for both gift-giving and receiving. Take the time to make space for new items before the holidays. After the holidays pass, conduct a post-holiday donation run to remove items you no longer need. A useful technique to prepare for the season is to stock your pantry more deeply so there are treats for guests and for any additional holiday cooking that might arise. This will reduce the holiday stress of running out sporadically for miscellaneous items.

These seasonal maintenance routines allow you to evaluate your system. Do your current maintenance routines appear to be working efficiently? If you discover there are a lot of miscellaneous items to handle, adjust or tweak your schedules or habits to be more optimal. These quarterly evaluations help to ensure your systems continue working for your benefit.

Customization: Creating Your Personal Maintenance Schedule

The previous schedules outlined in this chapter were a framework or baseline, not set in stone as rigid requirements. Perhaps you can start with this as a template, but customize the routine to adhere to your home's specific needs, your schedule, and your challenges.

For example, think about the size of your household. The more people there are, the messier things get and the more maintenance is required. A family of five will have different needs than a busy professional couple living without kids. Also, consider the age of your children. Toddlers create more of a mess and require more maintenance than teenagers. Those with toddlers will want to focus more on toy organization, while those with teenagers might focus more on paper organization and clothing.

Also, think about your work and related schedules. If you work the evening shift, the morning maintenance might be better than the evening reset. For some, mornings might be a rush to get to the office, so the morning routine, though small, might not be appropriate. Related to this, consider your personal energy level. In the morning, there simply may not be enough energy to initiate a morning routine. Conversely, if you're a morning person, consider shifting some of the evening routine to the morning.

You can create a custom schedule by first identifying hotspots. Identify areas where clutter accumulates the fastest, and these will be where you should focus your weekly attention. Second, try to assess how much time it will take you to complete the tasks. Third, you'll need to phase in your routines. This means starting with the daily routines and getting some type of rhythm. When the daily routines are solid, then layer in the weekly routines. After, build in the monthly routines. You want to build up the routines over time and not try to do everything at the onset.

To keep the maintenance on track, you can set a schedule of calendar reminders. Similarly, you can create a checklist for the daily, weekly, and monthly routines until you internalize them so that you don't forget them.

Try to involve all members of the family unit in the maintenance effort. Even your children can play roles in this process by assisting in clearing dishes, making their beds, or organizing their clothes. Try to be consistent when setting the maintenance schedules, as it's better for children to have an established routine to follow.

A Realistic Family Routine

In the following, we show a representative mock schedule for a family of four with two working parents and two children in school. It's designed to be illustrative and to give you a framework to modify as necessary.

Each day would start off with the daily maintenance routine, and this is something each family member can participate in. Before breakfast, each person takes the time to make their bed and check their bedroom—usually before 7:30 a.m., depending on the day. Each evening, the whole family is involved in the routine, with children assigned to clear stray items from the common area.

The parents will divide and conquer, with one parent handling the kitchen while the other tackles the bedrooms and bathrooms. This might occur around 8:30 p.m. each evening before the kids' bedtime.

In this schedule, the weekly maintenance occurs on Saturday morning. This includes hotspot checks of key areas identified for this household, including the entryway, dining table, and coffee table. This routine also includes the processing of paper held in the Sunday mail basket. One parent supervises the kids in busy play activities while the other handles the maintenance routines.

The monthly maintenance routine is scheduled for the last Sunday of the month in the afternoon. The focus will be on the deep dive scheduled for that month. Parents will focus on addressing the deep dive, and the kids will get free unstructured play after they have organized their rooms.

The seasonal maintenance is scheduled for the first Saturday of each quarter, starting with January. The family can work together performing clothing swaps, donation runs, and seasonal deep cleaning. This quarterly intensive maintenance schedule addresses areas that only need attention a few times a year.

Accountability and Motivation

Initially, try to track your progress so that you have the data to reset and adjust the process. Start by checking off the daily resets on a wall calendar. Once you begin to see a track record of consecutive streaks, this will support efforts and give you motivation when you're discouraged.

Eventually, life will happen, and you might fall off the wagon. This is natural, but you need to reset and get back on the wagon. Anything can happen: people get sick, work gets busy, vacations occur, and this list could go on. This is normal. Just spend some time putting the home into an organized state, reset, and maintain the regular schedule.

If your systems don't work effectively, then adjust them. Perhaps the daily tasks are too complex or too intensive. Then simplify them. If the weekly tasks are not done, reassess the schedule. Maybe the monthly tasks are too large. If so, break them down to make them work for your household. You need to find a sustainable rhythm rather than creating more stress.

The Long-Term Reality

Maintenance is a habit that continues forever; it's automatic. It's like brushing your teeth or drinking coffee. If performed consistently, there will be a point where it's like checking to see if the door is locked at night. You will naturally tidy up the home and return items to their locations or even evaluate new items before purchase.

The time invested in the maintenance is small compared to the decluttering efforts outlined in the prior chapters. Provided you continue with the maintenance, you will never again be overwhelmed with clutter in the magnitude described at the onset of this book. Your home will be more functional, calmer, and more organized, without a doubt.

If your home is chaotic, it drains the energy from you. When your home is organized, you have the mental space for work and feel greater support for all areas of your life. These maintenance routines are designed to protect and support your life. You want to have a home that functions smoothly and brings you peace.

CHAPTER 15

Mindful Living - Beyond the Physical Space



By working through this book, you've decluttered every room in your home. You assessed and evaluated your possessions and made difficult decisions to discard and donate items. Later, you adopted some systems or routines to maintain the order of your physical space.

Through this decluttering effort, you've asked questions like, "Is this item useful to me now or something from my past life?" This question was relevant during the decluttering process, but it's also relevant more broadly.

Digital Decluttering

We've touched on this earlier in the book, but digital clutter takes a mental toll just like physical clutter. Think of the number of notifications you receive. Some are useful; others are likely from subscribing to something long past. Perhaps you have emails flooding your inbox that are totally irrelevant to you. Then there

are photos and videos just taking up space on your devices. Digital hoarding is like physical hoarding and requires editing to maintain calmness.

Email Management

For email, start by actively unsubscribing. Try to do this every day for one week. Whether it's promotional emails, retail notifications, or anything else that's irrelevant, unsubscribe from everything except newsletters you read, services you use, and retailers you buy from.

One technique is to implement an **Inbox Zero** or **Inbox Twenty** approach. This approach sets the limit on the number of emails that can exist in your email at one time. The Inbox Zero approach simply means the email inbox count should be zero, whereas the Inbox Twenty is less restrictive, allowing for twenty emails. The goal is to not let your email inbox explode into temporary storage.

You want to treat your digital email like your physical mail by reading, answering, filing, or deleting it. Set aside some time when you can sort through email rather than continually checking it. Adopting this boundary will have the added benefit of keeping you focused on the present and reducing your stress.

Think of your email inbox as a to-do list rather than a large filing system. Those messages that require some type of action stay, whereas the rest should be filed or deleted.

Social Media Audit

Today, many spend countless hours on the phone, glued to social media. It's time to unfollow accounts that make you feel inadequate or anxious. Highlight reels on social media make many people feel insufficient or inadequate when comparing their real life with a

carefully curated video. This is not being unfriendly; it's being focused on your mental health.

Before following an account, be deliberate about it. Is the account adding value, or do you consistently feel worse after watching it? If you have apps you scroll through mindlessly, then it's time to delete them. As a starting point, rather than going cold turkey, consider limiting yourself to thirty minutes daily. If you remove the app and have a change of heart, it can be reinstalled. Generally, thirty minutes a day of social media is reasonable. Two hours is excessive for busy people.

Photo Management

With our mobile phones today, we tend to collect thousands of videos and photos over time and rarely go back to look at them. In the moment, we might take multiple photos hoping to capture a special pose, yet we never return to sort through the videos and photos.

Some people have started to set up monthly photo and video culling sessions. In these sessions, the duplicates, blurry shots, and screenshots are normally deleted. You don't need five of the same shot. Pick the best of the five and move on. The screenshots were probably temporary references, but their usefulness has long since passed.

Try to sort the photos into years and then events for easier reference and sharing in the future. Consider printing and displaying certain photos or events. Some people choose to display a digital photo frame that cycles through a set of photos from an online drive.

Desktop and File Organization

Some desktop computers are littered with files. The goal is to have a desktop computer with zero files, and this is achieved by using folders to organize everything. A computer full of files is visually chaotic. It's too hard to find the desired file with fifty file icons on your home screen. The folder structure should be clear: work, personal, and subcategories within each.

Examine the downloads folder. It's probably full of files you've copied to another folder or just left in this folder after using them. Sort this folder and delete files that haven't been used for over six months. This is similar to when we donated or trashed the physical items we hadn't used in over three months. Review all programs installed on your computer and delete those you haven't used in three months.

Like physically taking out the trash, empty that recycle bin. Your deleted files occupy space until you empty the trash folder. On your phone, examine your storage to see which large apps or video files are consuming most of the storage and purge items you don't need.

App Audit

Look through your phone; there will be apps that haven't been opened in the last six months. If you can't remember when you last accessed the app, then it's time to delete it. Later, if you find you need it, it can be reinstalled.

Digital Boundaries

Many of us are glued to our phones for various reasons—work, kids, or otherwise. For peace of mind, set some boundaries on the use of your phone. When you eat your meals without your phone, it helps to improve human connections and encourages more mindful

eating. Many people no longer sleep with their phones. Their phones are placed elsewhere, and they wake up with an alarm clock. This promotes more restful sleep and sidesteps the tendency to scroll on the phone late at night.

There should be free time during the day without your phone. For example, during the morning routine and evening family time, there's no need to be glued to the phone.

Are you constantly receiving push notifications for items that aren't relevant? Disable those nonessential notifications on social media, news, and promotional apps while keeping the lines open for calls, texts, and other essential communication.

This is a simple shift in mindset that changes your interaction with technology. You're choosing when to engage, when to disengage, and where you direct your attention. The pings and notifications are not constantly drawing you back to your phone.

Time Decluttering

Time is the one truly nonrenewable resource. You can't earn more time or save it for later. Over-commitment is the time equivalent of physical clutter. If you're busy running around with errands, kids, and invitations, that's a choice, but you can choose a different path. "Busy" is not a badge of honor. It's a choice, and you can choose differently.

Learning to Say No

Many of us are programmed to say yes to all requests, invitations, and get-togethers. This may be done out of convenience. Our calendar appears open, so we agree. Other times, it's done out of obligation. The invitation came from a particular person, and others are attending.

You can use scripts before deciding on impulse, allowing you to evaluate. The script might be “I need to check with my family’s schedules before responding.” This will set some expectations and some boundaries.

There is usually a cost or sacrifice for a commitment. If it’s a potluck, then you must prepare a meal for the event, get the kids ready, and juggle other items to meet the invite. Before committing to an event, spend some time evaluating it. Do you want to commit? If you say yes, what are the repercussions, and are there other things being declined? If, for some reason, you might regret going to the event, you should decline it right away.

Common Time Clutter

Over time, you may have become involved in a variety of events and committees for various reasons. It’s time to sit down and assess all these commitments and determine their relevance to your life and your family’s life today.

You might be involved in some committees out of obligation—for example, being the class helper for your child’s class. You might enroll your kids in piano because it’s good for them, but they don’t really like it. Sometimes you or your kids are somewhere stretching your capacity because you feel guilty about saying no. These obligations and routines tend to roll forward and may be relevant in one chapter of your life but not the next.

Simply list out your current commitments and assign a rough rating to them as essential, valuable, tolerable, or draining. The essential commitments are the basic life tasks, like work or health maintenance. These things you can’t do without. Valuable commitments are meaningful or bring joy. For some, that might be attending religious services. Tolerable commitments might be those that are somewhat neutral, maybe being the leader for your child’s

class. Draining commitments are those that suck the living energy out of you.

For draining commitments, exit gracefully. Give notice or find a replacement if necessary. In the future, be selective of what you commit to.

The Power of White Space

Downtime or white space represents unscheduled time where there are no plans and no agenda is set. It's a time to relax or to do whatever you feel like doing during that day. We need this time because we aren't built to run around every minute of every day without a pause from the grind. We can run around for some duration but not all day. Parents need unstructured rest, and kids need unstructured play. This time promotes creativity and reflection, allowing you to improve different aspects of your life.

You can create white space by simply blocking your calendar. This is similar to the technique at work of blocking time on your calendar to do something that's not yet known or defined. There's a need to build in a buffer between commitments and avoid running from one event to another back-to-back. If possible, try to have an unscheduled free day each week to do whatever comes up.

During your white space time, take note of how it makes you feel. Some might feel uncomfortable since they're more used to scurrying around and accomplishing something, while others feel like it's not productive. This is not being lazy or unproductive, but practicing maintenance. This practice will allow you to breathe and prevent burnout. Try to plan for white space in your schedule to protect your family's well-being.

Financial Decluttering

The source of physical clutter is often driven by financial clutter. For some, buying material items may make them feel better, and those useless purchases incur a sunk cost. There's a reluctance to discard them due to the sunk cost, leading to physical clutter. Decluttering can reverse this and lead to better financial habits through the discipline you developed in evaluating your possessions and future spending habits.

Subscription Audit

From a monetary standpoint, you should review and get a handle on your subscriptions. Subscriptions by their nature are designed to be forgotten. The automatic payment plan is used by the vendors to maximize their recurring revenue. Once you subscribe, the tendency is to forget you have the service and continue to pay the ongoing fee. The charges might seem small (for one forgotten service, maybe ten dollars per month), which isn't enough to raise red flags. But over the year, these amounts add up. If there are multiple subscriptions, these amounts add up.

Look through your bank records and credit card statements for recurring charges. When you notice subscriptions, examine to see if you are actively using that subscription and cancel those you are not using.

The common subscription culprits are streaming services, gym memberships, software, and even storage units. If you're paying for a storage unit, you should consider if it's worthwhile. Typically, storage units could cost a few hundred dollars per month. Perhaps it's time to declutter that unit and potentially cancel it.

The Shopping Pause

For those larger nonessential items you think you want to purchase, try implementing a shopping delay or pause before their purchase. Perhaps wait thirty days before purchasing. Most often, the need or desire for the item fades.

Each potential purchase should be examined through a series of questions to vet its need. Assess if there's space for the item. Is the item a duplicate? Will the item be used daily or weekly, or is it an aspirational item? Remember, aspirational items rarely get used. You probably trashed or donated many in the decluttering process.

Try to determine your shopping triggers. Was it because of a sale or a deal that you saw, but there was no real need for the product? Is it simply social pressure—your friends had it, so you needed to obtain a similar item?

Some behaviors might stave off the need to shop. Delete those shopping apps from your phone and unsubscribe from those retail emails. Perhaps try to rediscover what you have at home and can make use of rather than buying new things.

Budgeting as Space Making

Give some consideration to where you spend your money. It could be on experiences or on material items. There's evidence to support that experiences bring more lasting happiness than material possessions. When purchasing material possessions, invest in high-quality items rather than lower-quality and cheaper items. The cheaper fast fashion and disposable items cause clutter in the long term.

Take some time to recognize that, for most, money is finite. If you spend more on material possessions, there's less to spend on experience. This realization should drive your spending patterns.

Relationship and Commitment Decluttering

This is an area where you want to tread more lightly. It's about being more intentional about where you want to spend your energy socializing. Your energy is finite. You want to spend your energy on relationships that are nourishing rather than draining.

Energy Vampires Versus Energy Givers

Naturally, there will be people who energize you and those who drain your energy. Those who drain you might leave you feeling fatigued or burnt out after interacting with them. You want to limit your time with those who constantly drain your energy.

Set boundaries with those constantly draining your energy and moderate your interactions. Sometimes you might phase out of draining relationships; they naturally fade away. Other times, you'll need to cut them off abruptly. Investing your energy in relationships should be somewhat reciprocal, both giving and receiving energy.

Audit Your Social Commitments

Take inventory of your social commitments. Perhaps you attend or host some events out of obligation. If these aren't enjoyable, then bow out of them. Are you involved in some group chats that constantly ping notifications and stress you out? Consider muting them or leaving them altogether.

People evolve, and friendships may change over time based on your life chapter. Some friends might have different interests and walk different paths, which can cause relationships to change. Focus your energy on those relationships that matter the most.

Creating Space for What Matters

When you remove irrelevant items from your life, whether physical, digital, financial, or relational, you create space for things that align with your values. This is, in effect, the goal. This book was about creating that space.

Identify Your Core Values

You should have a good understanding of your core values. Some typical core values might be family connection, health, creativity, learning, financial security, and meaningful work. Determine your top three to five values and let these guide your decisions.

For example, let's say acquiring family connections is a core value. If you work late every night and are on your phone during dinner, then there's a conflict. Some possible decluttering solutions would be to stop reading emails after 7 PM, have phone-free dinners, and set aside other time for the family.

As another example, if health is a core value but you don't cook or go to the gym and experience chronic stress, then there's a problem. Some possible solutions are to create home-cooked meals, cancel the gym membership, and work out using an app at home.

Building a Life, Not Just an Organized Home

We started with decluttering, physical decluttering—that was the catalyst. The real transformation is to live with intention. Your choices about what to buy, spend time on, and commit to are anchored on whether these items serve you today.

There's a cascading effect from these actions. A clear home leads to a clear mind, which leads to better decisions, which results in a more peaceful life aligned with your values.

The Practice of Mindful Living

The practice of choosing awareness, intention, and alignment is not about perfection; it's about consistency. You're making small choices aligned with an intention. Sometimes this will be hard, as there will be work, family emergencies, health issues, and the list goes on. The skills you built protect you from the chaos. You can reset, reevaluate, and level set.

Allow yourself to grow and evolve, as this is inevitable. Revisit the space, commitments, and boundaries you set regularly because you're growing and things change. Stay intentional yet flexible.

Remember, your life is a book full of chapters. Now you've completed the decluttering chapter and turned the page. The new chapter is intentional living. As you move forward, you'll turn more pages, and a new chapter will emerge. The skills you've built up ensure you have clarity and can adapt to the transition.

Living Lightly, Living Well

Your journey started with clutter, overwhelming physical clutter. Now, you have a philosophy for living. It's more than the transformation of the organized closets and clear counters. You gained time through the systems you created and the reduced maintenance routines. You have more clarity about the things you value and are willing to protect them. Now, you have reduced anxiety and more mental space.

The solution is not to create a better organizational system; it's to have less to organize. This is the simple truth. It's not about more containers, more unique organizing products, or a bigger house; it is about having less stuff.

Before the decluttering journey, you probably felt guilty about not being organized enough, ashamed of the clutter, and exhausted

with the constant battle with the mess. After this journey, you feel more at peace with your space, guilt-free from unused possessions. It was never about you; it was always about the stuff.

Clutter is a result of the modern consumer culture combined with busy lives. It's not a failure but a product of being too busy with work, kids, life, and stuff. You learned that letting go of things is not wasteful, whereas keeping things wastes space, energy, and peace.

You have permission to release aspirational items. Systems beat willpower, and the decision framework eliminates decision fatigue. The maintenance routines are designed to prevent backsliding. Your success comes from preparation, not from better organization.

This really is a "less is more" situation. If you have fewer clothes, then getting dressed is easier. If there are fewer dishes, then cleanup is faster. If there are fewer toys, then the existing toys get more play time. If there are fewer commitments, then you focus more on those that matter. Your home should reflect your life, not an aspiration. Your home should be a place of rest, not a storage unit.

Living Lightly Going Forward

The concept of mindful living is choosing to live with awareness, intention, and alignment instead of being on autopilot. It's not a destination but a daily practice. Inevitably, there will be mistakes. Since you've reached the end of this book, you've gained the tools to pivot and reset. Now you can stop clutter before it begins to accumulate and overwhelm.

By now, you have some built-in guardrails to prevent clutter. Analytically, you can assess if a particular item is useful to your current life. The one-in, one-out rule actively prevents accumulation. The nightly resets and morning routine help maintain order. We've

established that it's okay to say no to commitments, and this protects your time and energy. These guardrails will propel you forward.

Don't forget that life happens, and you might fall off the wagon. This does not mean you failed. Children get sick, work gets busy, family needs change, and the list goes on. Draw on the reset techniques found in the book, put the place back in order, and reestablish your routines. Remember that it was not about perfection but about creating something functional and peaceful.

You have created a home that is supportive rather than stressing you out. Your possessions serve a purpose rather than creating a burden. This came about not by becoming a different person but by creating different systems, not by working harder but by owning less, and not by organizing more but by releasing more.

Welcome home. Welcome home to a mindful, intentional, clutter-free life!

A NOTE FROM ME TO YOU

If this book helped you breathe a little easier, find your keys a little faster, or finally let go of something that was weighing you down—I would be so grateful if you would take two minutes to leave a review on Amazon.

You can leave a review here:

https://www.amazon.com/review/create-review?asin=YOUR_ASIN

Your words matter more than you know.

Every review helps another overwhelmed person find this book at exactly the moment they need it most. Even a sentence or two makes a world of difference.

Thank you for trusting me with your home and your journey.

Now go enjoy the calm you've created.

You've earned it.

APPENDIX

FREE BONUS RESOURCES

Download Your Complete Decluttering Toolkit

1. Master Decluttering Tracker
2. Preparation Checklist
3. Three-Question Clutter Killer
4. Complete Room by Room Checklist
5. 30 Day Maintenance Tracker

SCAN THE QR CODE BELOW



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

ALEX LEE is a home organization advocate dedicated to helping busy people create peaceful, clutter-free spaces. Navigating the beautiful chaos of marriage, three kids, and a demanding career, Alex knows that perfection is a myth, but order is achievable. Through practical strategies and proven systems, Alex guides readers toward homes that support mental clarity and reduce daily stress.